

Community Needs Assessment

Learner guide | SWP-013 | School of Community & Macro Practice

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Community Needs Assessment. By the end of the course, you should be able to plan and conduct a participatory assessment that identifies needs, assets, and priorities.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Plan and conduct a participatory assessment that identifies needs, assets, and priorities.
- Apply the key ideas from Assessment design.
- Apply the key ideas from Collecting and interpreting evidence.
- Apply the key ideas from Prioritisation and communication.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. Assessment design	purpose, stakeholders, ethics, inclusion, and mixed-method choices	10 to 15 minutes
2. Collecting and interpreting evidence	surveys, interviews, focus groups, asset mapping, and data quality	10 to 15 minutes
3. Prioritisation and communication	ranking needs, validating findings, reporting back, and action recommendations	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 Assessment design

This module focuses on purpose, stakeholders, ethics, inclusion, and mixed-method choices. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Purpose
- Stakeholders
- Ethics
- Inclusion
- Mixed-method choices

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of assessment design in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of purpose, stakeholders, ethics, inclusion, and mixed-method choices. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through assessment design safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 Collecting and interpreting evidence

This module focuses on surveys, interviews, focus groups, asset mapping, and data quality. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Surveys
- Interviews
- Focus groups
- Asset mapping
- Data quality

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of collecting and interpreting evidence in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of surveys, interviews, focus groups, asset mapping, and data quality. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through collecting and interpreting evidence safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Prioritisation and communication

This module focuses on ranking needs, validating findings, reporting back, and action recommendations. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Ranking needs
- Validating findings
- Reporting back
- Action recommendations

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of prioritisation and communication in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of ranking needs, validating findings, reporting back, and action recommendations. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through prioritisation and communication safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: participatory methods.
- Review the distinction between: ethics.
- Review the distinction between: assets versus deficits.
- Review the distinction between: prioritisation.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.